

works on making both mobile and Web apps for its clients. Needless to say, the demand for mobile apps is increasing at a much faster pace than for Web apps. Singh says, "Mobile apps are in the thing. As the smartphones' ecosystem is improving and developing, the demand for app developers is growing."

Subhi Quraishi, CEO, ZMQ Software Systems, says, "This is an interesting time for software professionals. The world of app development has various career paths and they are all good. It is a growing field. Apps have become a necessity for all who want a digital presence. Modern day software development has grown to be app specific. Hence, anyone with a creative mindset and command over technology should be here to make it big."

Growth prospects

For someone looking to make a career in apps development, particularly in the mobile apps segment, the sky is the limit. If you go by the statistics, the number of mobile connections is more than TVs, landline phones and PCs in India. So whether it is entertainment, shopping, in-car navigation or banking, there is an app for it and there is scope for apps in every sphere of life. So, it won't be an exaggeration to say that apps will drive the growth of the mobile devices and PC industry henceforth.

It is worth mentioning here that Indian mobile operators are earning a major chunk of their revenue through Value Added Services (VAS). The demand for these has led to the increased demand for mobile app developers in a significant way. Singh emphasises, "The industry is booming and demand is high, but there is still a dearth of quality talent. By this I mean sound technical knowledge as well as creative ideas. Companies like us resort to training the developers in the domain to meet the demand." Appstudios has plans to add 100 developers this year, of which a majority would be freshers. Singh clarifies, "The college curriculum is still not up to the mark. Hence, the freshers we hire are first trained by the experts and then brought on to real projects. Of course, we definitely look for sound technical knowledge in freshers." This means that freshers without any experience in the apps development industry can also have their share of the apps development pie but have to undergo training.

Don't believe it? Well, you can scan any job site and you will find numerous jobs in the M-VAS (Mobile Value Added Services) industry. Therefore, rest assured that a career in this industry will prove to be a good move eventually.

Creativity is paramount

Sheer technical knowledge is not the only attribute required for success in this domain. You have to think

out-of-the-box to make it big here. Quraishi says, "This field is beyond technical knowledge. One must have a creative way of thinking to survive in this field. By 'creative' I mean anything out-of-the-box and yet user-friendly. Right from thinking about an app to executing it, one needs to value the fact that eventually the app is for a general user, who may or may not be tech-savvy. So, making an app that is easy to use is a perfect thing."

Desired skillsets

For someone looking to make a career in the apps development domain, a knowledge of programming languages including C, C++ and Objective C for writing applications on iOS (iPhone, iPad) and Java (Android and the BlackBerry OS) is a must. Of course, one cannot learn it all while in college, but you can always opt for short-term courses or a diploma in apps development, which are being widely offered across the country.

Apart from having a B Tech or an MCA degree, one is expected to have fairly good knowledge on browsers (WML and XHTML), gateways/servers (WAP, XML, VXML, WTA, etc), clients (SMS, e-mail, chat, etc) and stacks (WAP2.0 and TCP/IP). Developers are, of course, most in demand in the business, but there is a lot of scope beyond development as well. An app needs content and graphics as well, which makes the industry a career choice for content writers, graphic designers and researchers as well. Innovation and out-of-the-box thinking can enable freshers in the industry to grow quickly.

With the changing technology, keeping pace with industry trends, technological innovations and new products in the market is important for freshers, who must constantly update themselves with the latest developments. Android, iOS and Windows Phone are the latest in the mobile arena, and even they may soon be replaced by Ubuntu Phone, Sailfish and Firefox OS. Hence, keeping a tab on the latest technology can be really helpful to remain in demand.

That's not all. Apps are designed for clients and users. An app developer must understand the clients' requirements and their target audience's temperament, and should have the ability to make modifications promptly.

Pay packages

If you are good at your job, money is not a constraint. An app developer can easily get an annual package of Rs 300,000 to Rs 450,000 as a beginner. The early years could be difficult times, but you should not worry too much as the road you are treading will soon lead to a successful career. **END** 

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